

All the PM's MEN

An inside look at the few trusted advisers who wield immense power and are helping to shape the agenda of the prime minister in his second innings

By Saurabh Shukla

The very nature of its power, responsibilities and pivotal role in modern day governance makes the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) a parallel government. It was not so in the UPA's first term when Sonia Gandhi called the shots. In his second tenure, Manmohan Singh has quietly but firmly turned the PMO into a hyperactive power centre which is steering the Government agenda with a new independence and authority. The contrast with UPA-I is evident. It is here that key decisions become government policies and Manmohan's office, along with trusted economic advisers, is now planning and monitoring the projects that the prime minister has adopted as a personal crusade.

The prime minister's A-team is pushing 18 flagship programmes of the Government, including the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, the National Rural Health Mission and fast-tracking and monitoring each one through a delivery monitoring unit that has been set up in the PMO. Says Naresh Chandra, former cabinet secretary: "An effective PMO is a national requirement. Today there is a greater scope for the PMO to intervene and this can lead to effective implementation of key projects." This also keeps ministries on their toes since the PMO tracks progress on these projects. "We call it pincer monitoring," says a PMO official. One example was the Assam Gas Cracker project which was behind deadline. With constant prodding by the PMO, the Rs 5,000-crore project is back on track.

More importantly, the PMO is dictating the foreign policy agenda. When the prime minister was convinced that this was the right time for talks with Pakistan, he called Foreign Minister S. M. Krishna and culled the views of his senior colleagues and the opposition leaders, but finally went ahead with his own conviction that the time is ripe for talks. Besides, he makes his officials think out of the box, seeking opinions even from academics and strategic analysts. "If there was a real possibility to resolve the problems of Jammu and Kashmir, both internally and in their

external dimensions during President Musharraf's tenure, it was only because of Dr Manmohan Singh's capacity to explore new ideas and promote innovative thinking without compromising on national interest. A non-territorial settlement had become a distinct possibility because of such an approach," says Amitabh Mattoo, a former member of the National Knowledge Commission who was closely associated with the Kashmir roundtables.

Unlike many of its previous avatars where officials were known for their influence-peddling, under Manmohan's PMO this is completely taboo. A senior aide recalls that when he joined the PMO and met "the boss", Manmohan welcomed him into his team. When he was leaving, Manmohan wished him luck, but then added: "If you ever hear anything about my family using their influence bring it immediately to my notice." While probity is an essential ingredient, talent acquisition knows no boundaries. An IAS officer from the Gujarat cadre who won praise for relief work after the Gujarat carnage was quickly picked for the PMO. Another official, Shatrughan Singh, is being brought in from Uttarakhand, also a BJP-ruled state.

He has picked young officials from services, from the Railways to the police, and several are management graduates with proven records as doers. "The prime minister's leadership is defined by competence and trustworthiness which reflects in his PMO," says Harish Khare, media advisor to the prime minister. Another aspect of Manmohan's PMO is that performance is rewarded. "It motivates you and we feel humble that the country's prime minister appreciates our work," says an official. This is also a PMO with clear demarcation of territories. There are three minister of state rank officials—principal secretary TKA Nair, National Security Adviser Shiv Shankar Menon and Prithviraj Chavan, a political appointee, besides two dozen key officials. They are a well-calibrated mix of young and old and he has chosen trusted aides who mirror his personality. A profile of his A-team: